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The Gowanus Canal is a strange place. It seems equal parts beloved and behated. Inarguably, it is poisonous and poisons everything around it. It's also the most important part of a [banjo toss](#) (where would you toss a banjo, if not into a canal?), a [popular](#) site for [kayaking](#), and the reason developers are trying to make "[Little Copenhagen](#)" happen.

Sincere attempts to illustrate the Gowanus Canal are both abundant and diverse, including:

Almost 300 pictures of black silt, dredged from the depths, staged in catering trays.
Thousands of soil core logs (including smell annotations).
Photographs of every adjacent manhole.
Speculation on mutant wildlife ("[Ichthyologists are dubious](#)").
Press releases, for high-end mixed use groundbreakings.
Proposals for robots.
More than one account of dead bodies.
The suggestion that the microbes living in the canal might carry its remediation on their small shoulders.
And more, and weirder.

The Gowanus Futures Project is a way to coalesce the constellated reality of the canal in a digital archive, one that can be dredged by search query and reformulated into speculative possibilities.

It happens in three chapters.

Map:

Documents illustrating the canal, ranging from bureaucratic engineering studies to New York Post swill, are summoned by search query. The more you search, the more you find. You'll also see the search terms of anyone else on the website at the same time, and what they find will appear on your screen too.

Documents fall into one of the following categories:

gossip
date night
picnic ideas
fortune telling
cryptids
controversy
science project

art projects
weather report
smells
cyborgs

And connections appear between documents of like categories.

When you click, you will either see a blurb from the document (including a link to its external site) or a popup will show you the document in frame.

After you've clicked on enough documents, you have the option to enter a community meeting, where you can discuss what you've seen.

Community Meeting:

An echo of the invitation for community input which appears in the Superfund process. Similar to the map, you can see what any other active users input along with your own thoughts. Voices are made audible with a digital voice that reads the inputs aloud – like the document capture in the map, you can click on the pieces of feedback. Clicking makes them quiet. Enough clicks transfers you into the third chapter.

Oracle:

Markov chains trained on EPA reports, social media, and all language input by users over the life of the project generate contaminated prophecies that blur technical expertise with community speculation. It's a platform where the future isn't predetermined by cleanup schedules, but emerges through real-time collective engagement. Users contribute their own questions and observations, which feed back into the oracle's predictions, creating an accumulating corpus where bureaucratic language metabolizes with lived experience. The project positions speculation as an algorithmic remix of lived experience and the documentation one to several degrees removed.

Like a fever dream, after a little time with the oracle, you're redirected to the map, and the cycle starts over.